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SECURITY



**Sex toy maker Lovense
caught leaking users'
email addresses and
exposing accounts to
takeovers**

A security researcher says sex toy maker Lovense has failed to fully fix two security flaws that expose the private email addresses of its users and allow the takeover of any user's account.

The researcher, who goes by the handle BobDaHacker, [published details of the bugs on Monday](#) after Lovense claimed it would need 14 months to fix the flaws so as to not inconvenience users of some of its legacy products.

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IMAGE CREDITS:
ENIA SHULIM / GETTY IMAGES

Lovense is one of the largest makers of internet-connected sex toys and is said to have [more than 20 million users](#). The company made headlines in 2023 for becoming one of the first sex toy makers [to integrate ChatGPT into its products](#).

But the inherent security risks in connecting sex toys to the internet can put users at risk of real-world harm if something goes wrong, including [device lock-ins](#) and [data privacy leaks](#).

BobDaHacker said they discovered that Lovense was leaking people's email addresses while using the app. Although other users' email addresses were not visible to users in the app, anyone using a network analysis tool to inspect the data flowing in

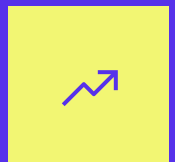
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and out of the app would see the other user's email address when interacting with them, such as muting them.

By modifying the network request from a logged-in account, BobDaHacker said they could associate any Lovense username with their registered email address, potentially exposing any customer who has signed up to Lovense with an identifiable email address.

"This was especially bad for cam models who share their usernames publicly but obviously don't want their personal emails exposed," BobDaHacker wrote in their blog post.

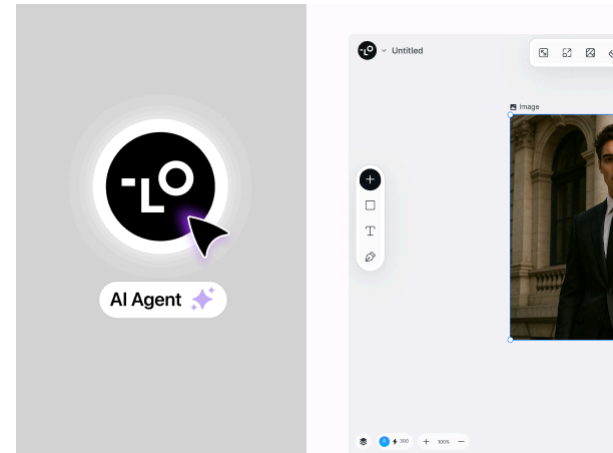
TechCrunch verified this bug by creating a new account on Lovense and asking BobDaHacker to reveal our registered email address, which they did in about a minute. By automating the process with a computer script, the researcher said they could obtain a user's email address in less than a second.

BobDaHacker said a second vulnerability allowed them to take over any Lovense user's account using just their email address, which could be derived from the earlier bug. This bug lets anyone create authentication tokens for accessing a Lovense account without needing a password, allowing an attacker to remotely control the account as if they were the real user.

"Cam models use these tools for work, so this was a huge deal. Literally anyone could take over any account just by knowing the email address," said BobDaHacker.

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The bugs affect anyone with a Lovense account or device.

BobDaHacker disclosed the bugs to Lovense on March 26 via the [Internet of Dongs](#), a project that aims to improve the security and privacy of sex toys and helps [report and disclose flaws to device makers](#).

According to BobDaHacker, they were awarded a total of \$3,000 via bug bounty site HackerOne. But after several weeks of back-and-forth disputing whether the bugs were actually fixed, the researcher went public this week after Lovense requested 14 months to fix the flaws. (Security researchers typically grant vendors three months or less to fix a security bug before going public with their findings.) The company told BobDaHacker in the same email that it decided against a “faster, one-month fix,” which would have required forcing customers using older products to upgrade their apps immediately.

The researcher notified the company ahead of disclosure, per an email seen by TechCrunch. BobDaHacker said in a blog post update on Tuesday that the bug may have been identified by another researcher as far back as September 2023, but the bug was allegedly closed without a fix.

Lovense did not respond to an email from TechCrunch sent prior to publication. After we published, a Lovense representative said the account takeover bug “has now been fully addressed” and that the email disclosure bug will be patched in an update expected to be “pushed to all users within the next week.” The representative would not commit to publicly notifying its customers about the bugs.

Updated with comment from Lovense.



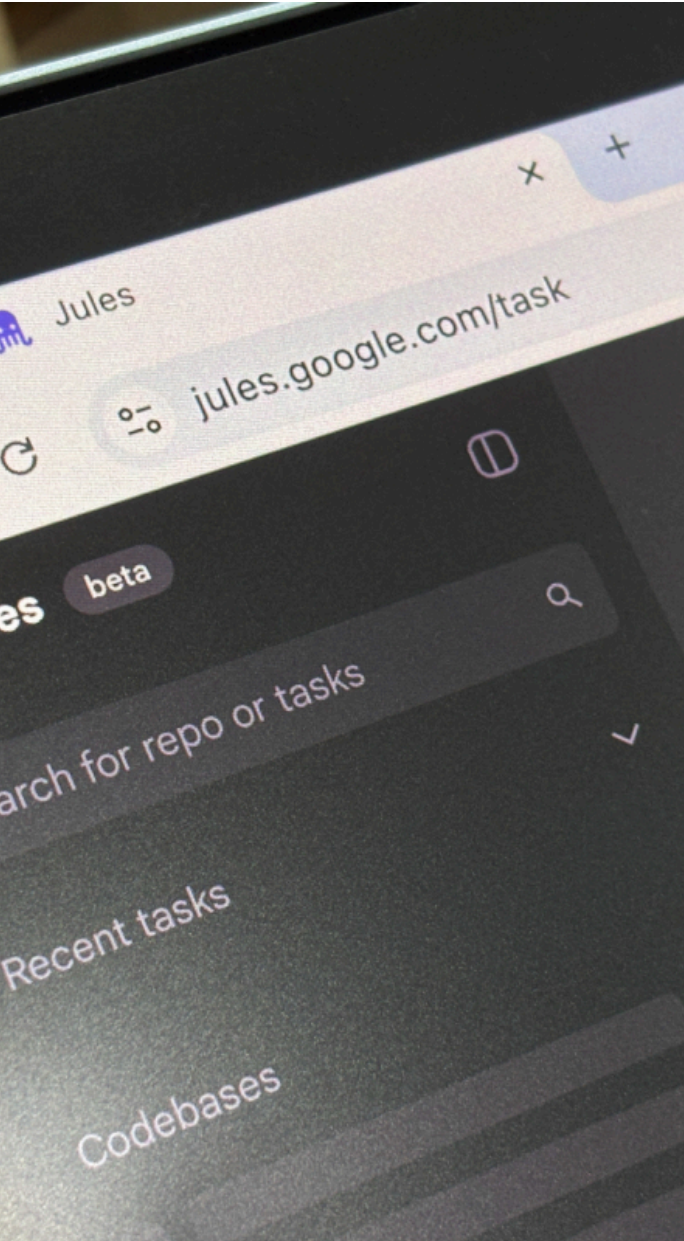
Zack Whittaker

Security Editor |

Zack Whittaker is the security editor at TechCrunch. He can be reached via encrypted message at...

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AI



Google’s AI coding agent Jules is now out of beta

Jagmeet Singh — 9:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

agent, Jules, out of beta, just over two months after its [public preview debut in May](#).

Powered by Gemini 2.5 Pro, Jules is an asynchronous, agent-based coding tool that integrates with GitHub, clones codebases into Google Cloud virtual machines, and uses AI to fix or update code while developers focus on other tasks.

Google [initially announced](#) Jules as a Google Labs project in December and made it [available to beta testers](#) through a public preview at its I/O developer conference.

Kathy Korevec, director of product at Google Labs, told TechCrunch that the tool's improved stability drove the decision to take it out of beta after receiving hundreds of UI and quality updates during its beta phase.

"The trajectory of where we're going gives us a lot of confidence that Jules is around and going to be around for the long haul," she said.

With the wider rollout, Google introduced structured pricing tiers for Jules, starting with an "introductory access" free plan capped at 15 individual daily tasks and three concurrent ones, down from the 60-task limit during beta. Jules' paid tiers are part of the Google AI Pro and Ultra plans, which are priced at \$19.99 and \$124.99 a month, and offer subscribers 5x and 20x higher limits, respectively.

Korevec noted that Jules' packaging and pricing are based on "real usage" insights gathered over the past couple of months.

"The 60-task cap helped us study how developers use Jules and gave us the information we needed to design the new packaging," she said. "The 15/day is

designed to give people a sense of whether Jules will work for them on real project tasks.”

Google also updated Jules’ privacy policy to be more explicit about how it trains AI. If a repository is public, its data may be used for training, but if it is private, Korevec said that no data is sent.

“We got a little bit of feedback from users that it [the privacy policy] wasn’t as clear as we thought it was, and so most of it is just responding to that. We didn’t change anything about what we’re doing on the training side, but we changed the language,” Korevec said.

During the beta, Google said that thousands of developers tackled tens of thousands of tasks, resulting in over 140,000 code improvements shared publicly. Initial feedback led the Google Labs team to add new capabilities, including reusing previous setups for faster task execution, integrating with GitHub issues, and supporting multimodal input.

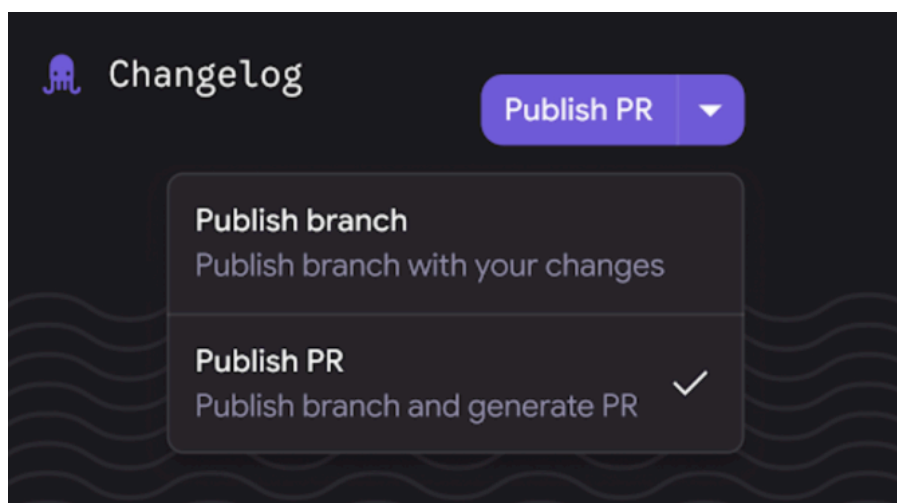


IMAGE CREDITS: JULES / X

The two primary users of Jules so far are the AI enthusiasts and professional developers, Korevec said.

By running asynchronously in a virtual machine, Jules stands apart from top AI coding tools like Cursor, Windsurf, and Lovable, which all work

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synchronously and require users to watch the output after each prompt.

“Jules operates like an extra set of hands ... you can basically kick off tasks to it, and then you could close your computer and walk away from it if you want and then come back hours later. Jules would have those tasks done for you, versus if you were doing that with a local agent or using a synchronous agent, you would be bound to that session,” Korevec explained.

This week, Jules received a deeper integration with GitHub to [open pull requests automatically](#) — just like it could open branches — and a feature called [Environment Snapshots](#) to save dependencies and install scripts as a snapshot for faster, more consistent task execution.

From vibe coding to mobile use, beta trials informed Jules’ development

Since entering public beta, Jules has logged 2.28 million visits worldwide, 45% of them from mobile devices, per data from market intelligence provider [SimilarWeb](#), reviewed by TechCrunch. India was the top market for traffic, followed by the U.S. and Vietnam.

Google did not share specifics on Jules’ user base and its top geographies.

Korevec told TechCrunch that during the beta, the team observed that many people used Jules from traditional vibe-coding tools to either fix bugs that might have been implemented or extend the vibe-coded project to make it more production-ready.

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Originally, Jules required users to have an existing codebase. But Google soon realized many potential users — like those trying other AI tools — might want to explore it without one. Korevec said the company quickly enabled Jules to work even with an empty repository. That helped increase its scope and usage.

Google Labs’ team also noticed an increasing number of users accessing Jules through their mobile devices. Although the tool does not have a dedicated mobile app, Korevec said users were accessing it through its web app.

“Since it’s a big use case that we’re seeing emerging, we’re absolutely exploring what the features are that people need on mobile a lot more,” she noted.

Alongside beta testers, Korevec stated that Google already uses Jules to help develop some projects internally, and there is now a “big push” to use the tool on “a lot more projects” at the company.

Topics: [AI](#) [Google](#) [Google Jules](#) [jules](#)

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Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

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IMAGE CREDITS: TEAONHER (MODIFIED)

Amanda Silberling, Zack Whittaker
12:40 PM PDT · August 6, 2025

TeaOnHer, an app designed for men to share photos and information about women they have supposedly dated, has exposed users' personal information, including government IDs and selfies, TechCrunch can confirm.

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The app, which launched on the Apple App Store earlier this week, is a response to another viral app Tea that allows women to post about the men they date. Tea is advertised as a women's safety app with more than 6 million users that is similar to "[Are we dating the same guy?](#)" Facebook networks. However, the app is controversial, since many of the claims that women post cannot be verified.

The backlash surrounding Tea escalated last week, after 404 Media reported 4chan users retaliated by [discovering a publicly exposed database](#) belonging to the app, which [revealed](#) over 72,000 images, including thousands of selfies and photo IDs submitted for account verification. A [subsequent hack](#) exposed more than 1 million private messages sent over the app, prompting the app to [disable](#) its messaging feature.

TeaOnHer, which is now ranked No. 2 among Lifestyle apps on iOS, appears to be a direct rebuttal to the Tea app, even copying the language from Tea's App Store description in its own listing.

But like the app it sought to emulate, TeaOnHer contains security flaws of its own.

TechCrunch has found at least one security flaw that allows anyone access to data belonging to TeaOnHer app users, including their usernames and associated email addresses, as well as driver's licenses and selfies that users uploaded to TeaOnHer. Images of these driver's licenses are publicly accessible web addresses, allowing anyone with the links to access them using their web browser.

In one case, TechCrunch saw a list of posts shared on TeaOnHer appended with each user's email address, display name, and self-reported location.

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Data breach at French telecom giant Bouygues affects millions of customers

Zack Whittaker - 15 hours ago

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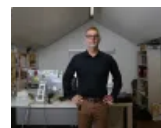


TeaOnHer, a rival Tea app for men, is leaking users' personal data and driver's licenses

Amanda Silberling,
Zack Whittaker

- 1 day ago

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Citizen Lab director warns cyber industry about US authoritarian descent

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchieri

- 2 days ago

TechCrunch is withholding some of the details of the bugs so as to not help malicious actors access anyone's data. The app's maker did not respond to emails from TechCrunch asking who we can report the flaws to. As such, TechCrunch is publishing this report with limited details of the issue, given the app's current popularity and the risk faced with using the app.

TeaOnHer was uploaded to the iOS App Store by a developer named Newville Media Corporation. According to LinkedIn, the founder and CEO of this company is Xavier Lampkin.

TechCrunch identified at least one TeaOnHer record associated with Lampkin's own data.

The security lapse will likely affect any user who signed up or shared identity documents with the app. The bug also exposes the number of users the TeaOnHer app has, which is about 53,000 users at the time of publication.

TechCrunch also identified a potential second security issue, in which an email address and plaintext password belonging to the app's creator, Lampkin, was left exposed on the server. The credentials appear to grant access to the app's "admin" panel. TechCrunch did not use the credentials, as doing so would be unlawful, but highlights the risks of inadvertently leaving admin credentials exposed to the web.

Along with its security flaws, the content portrayed within TeaOnHer is troubling in itself. While the app requests IDs and selfies from its users to verify their identities — a process that is not automatic — users can access a "guest" view of the app without signing in.

Immediately upon opening "guest" view, TechCrunch saw several images of the same naked

woman, posted under different names in a form of spam. It is not clear if this woman consented to this photo being shared. Other posts share the photos and names of women, alongside comments calling them “easy,” or accusing them of spreading sexually transmitted infections.

Across all free apps, TeaOnHer is ranked No. 17, higher than apps like Instagram, Netflix, Uber, and Spotify. Tea is currently ranked No. 2.

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Amanda Silberling

Senior Writer |

Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She...

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Zack Whittaker

Security Editor |

Zack Whittaker is the security editor at TechCrunch. He can be reached via encrypted message at...

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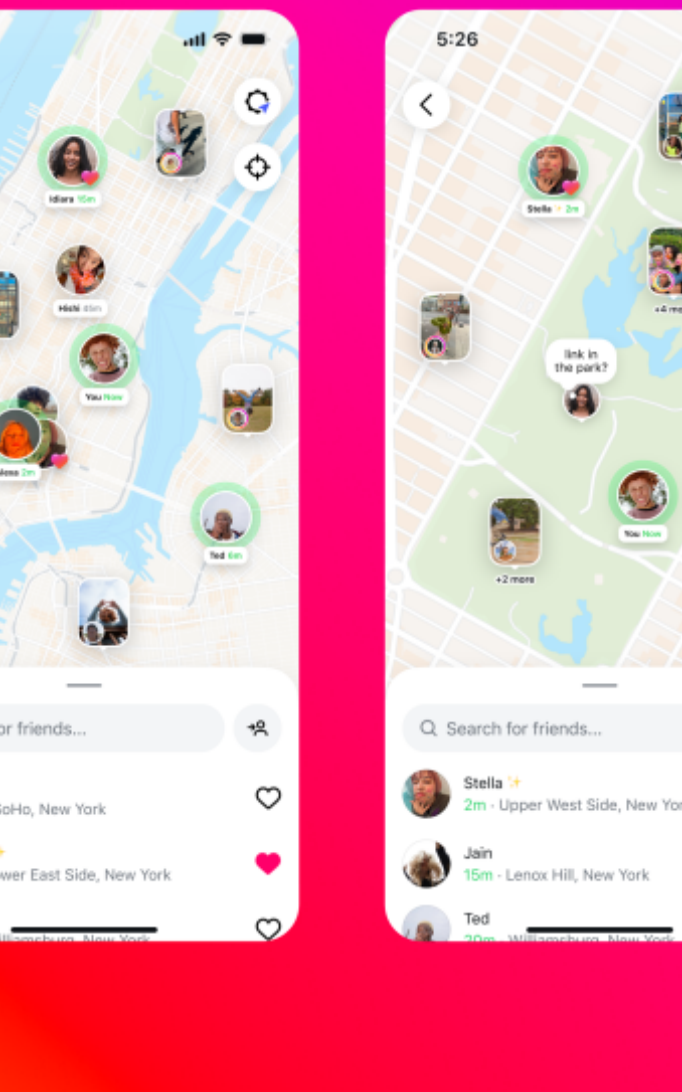


IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

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Instagram takes on Snapchat with new ‘Instagram Map’

Aisha Malik — 7:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Instagram is rolling out Instagram Map, a new feature that lets users share their most recent active location with others and discover location-based content. The Meta-owned social network is also launching reposts, and making its “Friends” tab in Reels available globally.

With its new map feature, Instagram is copying yet another popular feature from Snapchat, after cloning the app’s core Stories functionality [back in 2016](#). Instagram is coming for Snap Map’s crown, a feature that recently surpassed 400 million monthly active users and remains one of the app’s core offerings.

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Instagram notes that location sharing is off by default on Instagram Map, and a user's location only updates when they open the app, meaning it doesn't provide real-time location updates. Snap Map, on the other hand, allows users to choose whether their location is updated only when they open the app or in real time.

It's worth noting that Instagram does offer [real-time location sharing via DMs](#) (direct messages). However, unlike Apple's Find My and Snap Map, which let you share your location with others indefinitely, Instagram only lets users do so for up to one hour.

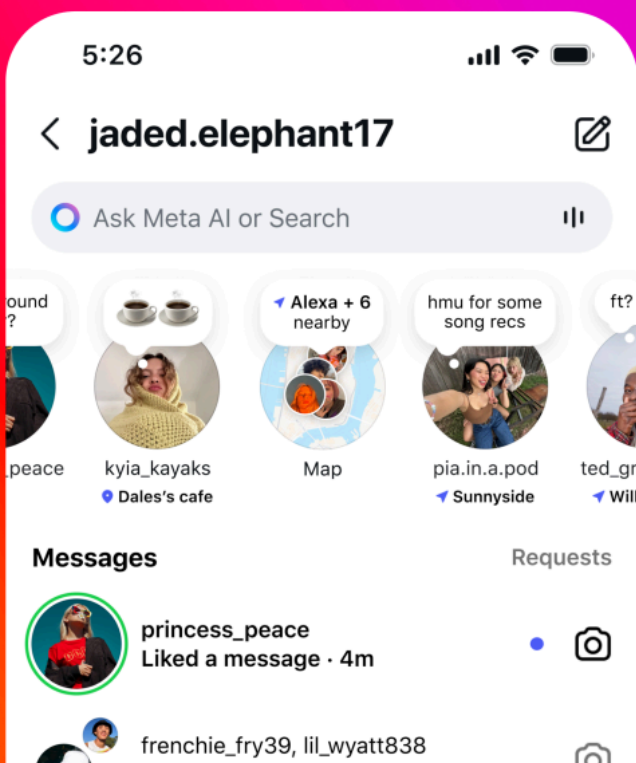


IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

Instagram says the new map feature will make it easier for friends to coordinate and link up for hangouts. It also lets users explore location-based content that their friends and favorite creators have shared or engaged with. For example, if your friend attends a nearby music festival and posts a story while there, it will appear on the map. Similarly, if a

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creator posts a reel about a new restaurant in your city, you'll be able to discover it on Instagram Map.

Regardless of whether you choose to share your location, you can use the map to explore location-based content, Instagram says.

The map also allows users to leave short messages, or [“Notes,”](#) on the map for others to see. Instagram Notes are currently the short messages that appear at the top of your direct messaging feed, but with the launch of Instagram Map, users can now post these short updates on the map.

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Although Instagram is certainly taking on Snapchat with this new feature, it also has the opportunity to appeal to people who were fans of [Zenly](#), a social map app that Snap acquired and then shut down in 2023.

The new map feature is launching in the United States starting Wednesday, with broader global availability coming soon. Users can find the Instagram Map at the top of their DM inbox.

The launch doesn't come as a surprise, as [Instagram was spotted developing](#) the map feature last year.

IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

As for the new "Reposts" feature, Instagram is taking a page out of [TikTok's book](#) while also creating its own version of the popular "retweet" function from Twitter (now X).

This feature lets Instagram users repost public reels and feed posts. These reposts may show up in their friends' feeds and will also be displayed in a new "Reposts" tab on their profile. Instagram says the new feature gives users a way to share their interests with others and also offers creators the opportunity to reach a wider audience.

To repost a reel or post, users tap the repost icon. Users can also choose to add a note to the repost by typing into the thought bubble that appears on screen and pressing save.

Regarding the new “Friends” tab in Reels, Instagram launched it in the United States earlier this year and is now making it available globally. The tab lets you see public reels that your friends have liked, commented on, reposted, and created.

For users who want to browse and interact with content privately, Instagram is rolling out the ability to opt out of having content you’ve engaged with shown in the friends tab.

Users can hide their likes, comments, and reposts from the tab. Additionally, they can choose to mute likes, comments, and reposts from specific people they follow.

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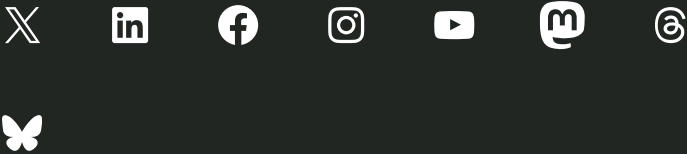
Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter | [X](#) [🦋](#) [in](#)

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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